



review

Genre: Third person action
Platform: Xbox 360
Studio: From Software
Publisher: Microsoft
Number of players: 1

Score: 7/10

NINJA BLADE

Sameer Desai

Ninja Blade is the kind of game that can go unnoticed. This hack 'n' slash game seems at first glance eerily similar in style, setting and even name, to the massively popular *Ninja Gaiden* series. Understandably, when *Ninja Blade* was announced, many shrugged it off as simply a *Ninja Gaiden* clone. But being an Xbox 360 exclusive and published by the platform owner does have its benefits, and as a result *Ninja Blade* attracted the attention the developers would have wanted. But is it able to shrug off the 'clone' tag and match up to competing titles in the genre?

Ninja Blade is not a *Ninja Gaiden* clone. In fact, it's quite a departure. While *Ninja Gaiden*'s USP is its punishing difficulty, *Ninja Blade* stresses more on the cinematic aspects of the combat, more like *Devil May Cry*. Some of the cinematic sequences are so over the top that it'll actually give *DMC* a run for its money, as improbable as that might seem. But, while combat may not be as punishing as *Ninja Gaiden*, it does offer up a lot of variety in the form of different weapons, huge mutant enemies, intriguing boss fights, and some of the most awesome finishing moves you'll ever see.

You play a member of a highly-trained team of ninjas, who are sent to Tokyo to combat an outbreak of a parasite that infects humans, turning them into giant mutant monsters; the stuff ninjas are trained for. Unfortunately, your team ends up dead, leaving you to fight a lone battle. A moderately interesting story unfolds through the game, and while it won't be winning any awards, it does have its moments.

Combat is the cornerstone of a hack 'n' slash, and *Ninja Blade* actually handles it quite well. In your arsenal you have a selection of swords, each ideal for specific kinds of targets. You also have magical powers, known as Ninjutsu, to help you take out enemies and clear paths. The protagonist, Ken Ogawa, is also pretty nimble on his feet, able to perform acrobatic wall

runs, both horizontally and vertically, and these abilities form a vital part of the game's many boss fights.

Ninja Blade is heavily reliant on quick time events or QTEs, which play out a sequence by requiring you to push a particular button at a specified time. Timing the button presses correctly lets you progress through the sequence. While this can get frustrating in many games, the QTEs work quite well here and aren't as frustrating or unforgiving as in other games. If you fail, you can try again rather than having to go back to the last checkpoint, and you have a generous time window in which to press the required button. QTEs may feel like cheating, especially when you see your character performing such thrilling manoeuvres and all you're doing to make that happen is push a button. But you won't really mind that because you're going to want to watch some of the outrageous set pieces in this game.

You can carry three weapons, and as you progress, you can upgrade these weapons to make them more powerful. You can also, if you choose, customise the look of your character. Combat itself is pretty easy and the smaller enemies will pose no challenge at all. To make up for that, there are multiple boss fights thrown at you, and while these aren't particularly challenging either, they're a lot of fun, and they ensure that the pace of the game is never anything but incessant.

The one big drawback to *Ninja Blade* is that there's nothing here that hasn't been done before in hack 'n' slash games, and there isn't much variation or uniqueness in the implementation of those methods either. The game isn't all that difficult, either, so veterans of games like *Ninja Gaiden* won't really find much of a challenge here. But that having being said, what it does, it does quite well. The boss fights are fun, the cinematic set pieces are some of the most entertaining, and the game plays out at a frantic pace from start to finish. *Ninja Blade* may not be a genre-defining game, but it's one that fans of the genre, and in fact, fans of action games in general, might want to try out. ■

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

